> the horizon became invisible, and a fierce wind arose, uprooting trees. Thick dark clouds blew in with terrifying thunder-claps and flashes of lightning. As more snow fell, the frost bit hard and all was covered in white powder like camphor. The English troops froze, their finger-tips fell off by segments, the soft tissue fell off their bones, even their feet separated from their ankles; living and dead were indistinguishable, motionless in the frozen wastes. The Afghan tribes who were used to such harsh conditions, crowded the hills and rushed down to plunder the helpless English troops. They found them half dead, or frozen solid like stones, no longer caring about their weapons, their gold, their possessions, barely conscious at all, each only just aware of his own dire condition.[47]

That evening, Elphinstone effectively acknowledged that his troops were doomed and gave over all the British women – or at least those of officer class – into the hands of Akbar Khan.[gg] Throughout the day, Akbar had hovered on the tail of the column insisting that he was doing everything he could to restrain the Ghilzai, but claiming that even their chiefs could not restrain them now they had tasted blood. Instead he offered to save the women and children and any wounded officers who wanted to give themselves up. In the end nineteen of them – two men, eight women and nine children – were escorted away. Lady Sale and her daughter Alexandrina had just watched Sturt die, strapped to the back of a shivering pony. ‘The rough motion increased his suffering and accelerated his death,’ wrote Lady Sale, ‘but he was still conscious that his wife and I were with him; and we had the sorrowful satisfaction of giving him a Christian burial?. . .’ Later, as she recounted,

> overwhelmed by domestic affliction, neither Mrs Sturt nor I were in a fit state to decide for ourselves whether we would accept the Sirdar’s protection or not. There was but faint hope of our ever getting safe to Jalalabad; and we followed the stream . . . We were taken by a very circuitous route to the Khoord Kabul forts where we found Mahomed Akbar Khan, and the other hostages. Three rooms were cleared out for us, having no outlets except a small door to each; and, of course, they are dark and dirty . . . At midnight, some mutton bones and greasy rice were brought to us. All that Mrs Sturt and I possess are the clothes on our backs in which we quitted Kabul . . .[48]

For the British, this surrender of their women into the hands of men they had come to regard as brutal savages was the moment of their greatest humiliation. For the Afghans, in contrast, the protection offered to the British memsahibs was seen as a mark of their own chivalry. ‘Commander Akbar Khan, though taken up with ruthless fighting, saw the dreadful